

Z.AI Co. (2513.HK): GLM-5.3 performance uplift brings post-training scaling at the focus; Neutral

We view the GLM-5.3 launch as another meaningful step-up in Chinese AI model progress, as Zhipu (Z.ai) attributed the performance uplift entirely from post-training scaling (on GLM-5.2, with unchanged 744bn parameter size, and outperformed the latest DeepSeek V4 Pro of 1.6T parameter sizes across various benchmarks). GLM-5.3 achieved material gains in coding, long-horizon task execution (with further cost efficiency per task) and cybersecurity performances, and we continue to await its next larger trillions-parameter sized model (GLM-5.5), and various 2T to 5T parameters-sized models to be launched by other Chinese AI model companies over the next few months.

Key highlights from GLM-5.3 include: 1) further post-training scaling, through longer task environments, longer training duration and reinforcement learning framework upgrades (IndexShare, SAO and Slime); **2) leading open-source coding performance and improved token efficiency**, with GLM-5.3 ranking amongst the top in open-source models (under MIT license without commercial restrictions/revenue sharing terms), across multiple coding benchmarks and approaching global frontier with more efficient cost metrics per task, and model weights scheduled to be released in 2 weeks; **3) training environments extending from coding problems to end-to-end expert workflows**, enabling the model to independently progress from problem discovery and analysis to implementation and validation; and **4) emerging cybersecurity capabilities**, with expanded capabilities across code review and vulnerability discovery/validation.

We also note other developments around harness-led data flywheels and model pricing power/more rational industry pricing normalization:

1) Harness products increasingly closing the loop across distribution, monetization and model training: Zhipu upgraded ZCode, its GLM-optimized coding harness product that surpassed 1mn active users, including remote control that enables users to manage tasks across devices, as well as multiple specialized agents collaboration. We note the introduction of idle-time tasks as a bright spot, which allows users to submit time-insensitive long horizon tasks for automatic execution during off-peak periods without consuming Coding Plan credits, to improve Zhipu's inference capacity utilization while offering users more cost effective access. We view ZCode as strategically valuable beyond distribution and monetization, as growing usage generates long-horizon, real-world coding trajectories that can feed back into subsequent model post-training.

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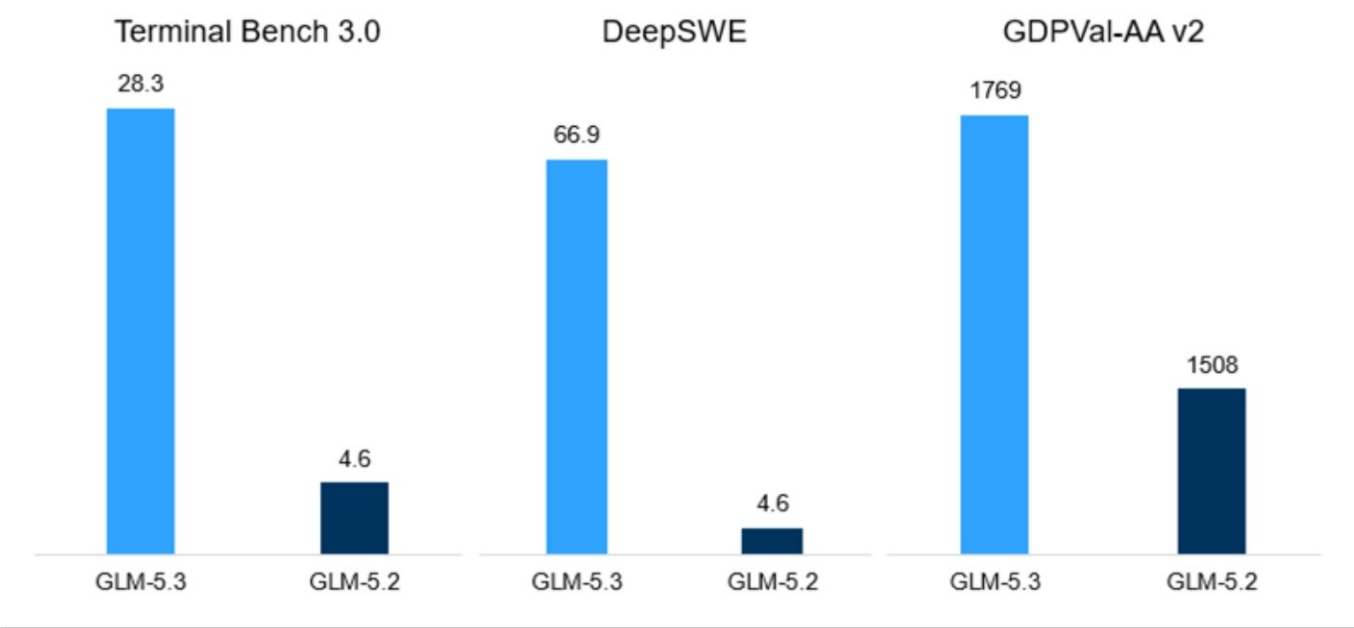
2) Increasing rational industry model pricing normalization alongside higher

intelligence: Zhipu reopened GLM Coding Plan subscriptions with credit-based billing, where Lite plan is priced at Rmb118/mo, while offering a c.50% discount to equivalent API cost based on the company's indicated weekly token allowance (yet above the effective cost under previous plans, which offered a deeper 70%-80% discount). Meanwhile, DeepSeek raised prices across its V4 APIs, with V4 Pro 0813 version's peak-hour blended 1M token price reaching US\$0.69, approaching GLM-5.2 level at US\$0.88. We view these updates as further evidence that higher model intelligence and task-completion capabilities are increasingly supporting pricing power/normalization.

Neutral with unchanged estimates/TP. Our 12-m TP of HK\$1,610 is based on a DCF valuation, with 12% WACC and 2% terminal growth rate (consistent with our coverage) that assumes continued market share gain to 21% market share by 2030E, and a long-term adj. EBIT margin of 26% by 2035E. Our bull case implied valuation is HK\$3,266 and our bear case implied valuation is HK\$835, based on key assumptions in [Exhibit 6](#). We are Neutral rated on Zhipu on balanced risk-reward, one of China's top AI model companies on model intelligence/capabilities, currently at US\$75bn market cap (implying 30X on GSe \$2.5bn year-end 2026E ARR), vs. peers DeepSeek at US\$50bn last valuation, and MiniMax at US\$14bn market cap (implying 14X on GSe \$1bn year-end ARR). Even though at more than double MiniMax's ARR multiple, we believe Zhipu's valuation premium is justified and are similar to P/ARR ratios of AI companies at around the same stage of ARRs. We do note Zhipu's valuation premium has narrowed over the past two months, as industry competition has evolved, with narrower model performance gap between peers. However, our views on the company remain: 1) we believe Zhipu's unique data flywheel will sustain its GLM model's superior performance-to-price balance in coding, 2) reported ARR likely understates underlying GLM model demand/adoption, given an open-source approach, where we expect significant ARR upside as ASICs/inference chip capacity ramp up over the next few years, 3) we believe a shift from open-source towards open-weight (with terms for commercial use) could be a potential path to realize full revenue/profit potential long-term.

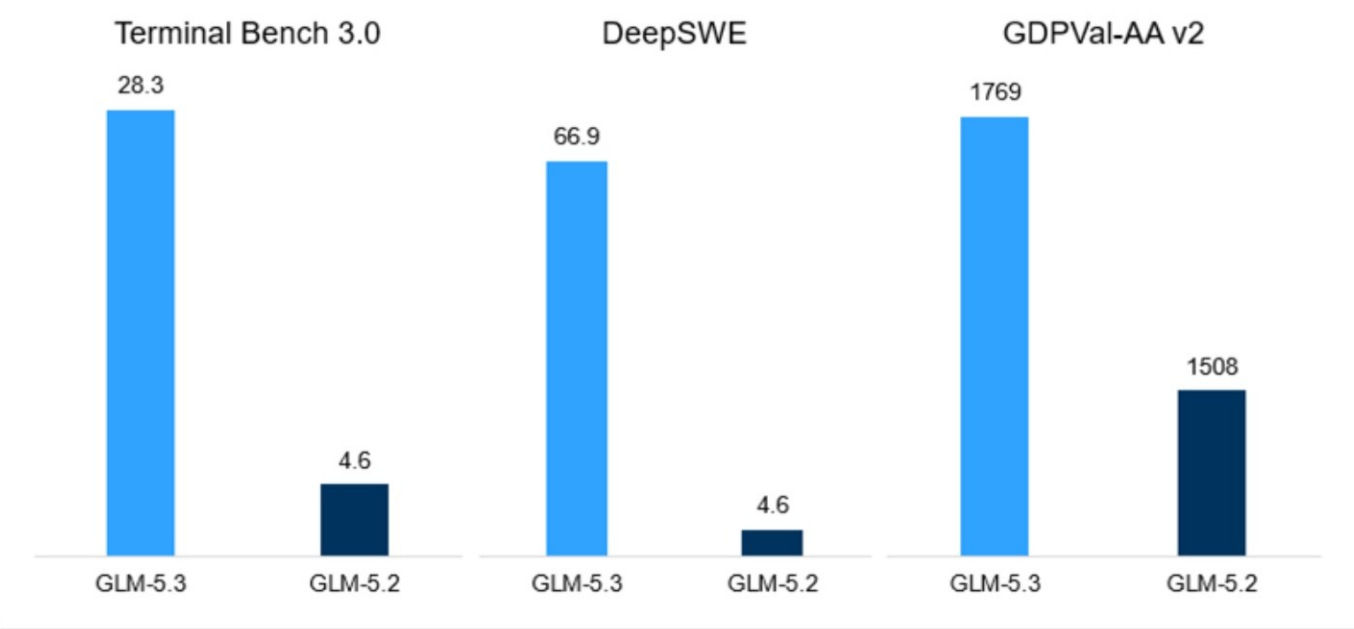
Key risks: (+) Stronger-than-expected model intelligence, (+) Faster-than-expected path to profit visibility, (+) Additional non-inference take rate revenue streams, (+) Stronger-than-expected commercialization capability, (-) Competition in global foundation model industry, (-) Limited near-term profit visibility due to high R&D expenses, (-) Cash burn/self-funding capability, (-) Risk around geopolitics under an intensified tech race between the US and China.

Exhibit 1: GLM-5.3 achieved substantial improvements across coding/agentic benchmarks vs. GLM-5.2



Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: With strengthened cybersecurity performance alongside intelligence improvements



Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: DeepSeek V4 Pro repricing (increase by 2-12X) signals potential pricing normalization (as of mid-Aug 2026)

Rmb/1M tokens	Old flat price	New off-peak price	New peak-hour price	Multiplier
Cached input	0.025	0.15	0.3	6-12X
Uncached input	3	4.5	9	2-3X
Output	6	13.5	27	2-5X
Blended (7:2:1)	1.2	2.4	4.7	2-4X
Blended (US\$)	0.18	0.34	0.69	

Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: LLM token index shows gradual convergence between closed and open-source model pricing, where blended price per 1M tokens continues to drop


Source: Silicon Data

Exhibit 5: Z.AI - Income statement

December year-end (Rmb mn)	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E
On-premise deployment	113	264	534	1,103	1,836	2,712
yoy %		134%	102%	107%	66%	48%
Cloud-based deployment	12	48	190	7,473	22,790	55,188
yoy %		307%	293%	3825%	205%	142%
Revenue	125	312	724	8,575	24,626	57,900
yoy %		151%	132%	1084%	187%	135%
Cost of sales	(44)	(137)	(428)	(6,246)	(17,641)	(41,218)
Gross (loss)/profit	80	176	297	2,329	6,985	16,682
yoy %		-119%	69%	685%	200%	139%
GP Margin %	65%	56%	41%	27%	28%	29%
Other income			2	10	19	15
Selling and distribution expenses	(101)	(387)	(391)	(586)	(774)	(1,107)
Administrative expenses	(66)	(134)	(505)	(733)	(975)	(1,433)
Research and development expenses	(529)	(2,195)	(3,180)	(6,234)	(11,532)	(16,630)
Operating profit	(626)	(2,538)	(3,787)	(5,190)	(5,855)	(2,283)
Adj. operating profit - non-IFRS	(620)	(2,515)	(3,228)	(4,492)	(5,017)	(1,320)
yoy %	-535%	-305%	-28%	-39%	-12%	74%
OP Margin %	-498%	-805%	-446%	-52%	-20%	-49%
(Loss)/Profit before tax	(788)	(2,958)	(4,718)	(5,229)	(5,893)	(2,322)
Income tax expense	-	-	-	-	-	-
Net profit/(loss)	(788)	(2,958)	(4,718)	(5,229)	(5,893)	(2,322)
Adj. net profit/(loss) - non-IFRS	(621)	(2,466)	(3,182)	(4,531)	(5,056)	(1,359)
yoy %	-537%	-297%	-29%	-42%	-12%	73%
NP Margin %	-499%	-789%	-439%	-53%	-21%	-2%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Z.AI: Our valuation bull/bear/base scenarios

Scenarios for valuation	Bear case 2027E EV/Sales-based	Base case DCF-based	Bull case DCF-based, mid-2028E ARR-implied
Z.AI	Applying 6X EV/Sales multiple to 27E open API platform revenue. Bear case valuation implies Zhipu's revenue pool share declines from 18% to 15% from 2027 to 2030E on higher competition.	Assuming Zhipu's revenue pool share to expand from 18% in 2027 to 21% by 2030E, and 26% EBIT margin (by 2035E). Applying 12% WACC and 2% terminal growth rate (consistent with our coverage).	Bull case valuation assumes Zhipu's revenue pool share to expand from 18% in 2027 to 32% by 2030E. Implies 28X mid-2028E ARR, discounting back using 12% p.a.
Valuation per share (HK\$)	835	1610	3266
Valuation (US\$bn)	50	95	195

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Related research

[Navigating China Internet/AI models: Focuses on harness & model performance vs. price; multi-modal highlights; top AI/apps tracker](#), August 3, 2026

[Navigating China AI models: LLM primer: Critical point of intelligence for global proliferation](#), July 10, 2026

[Knowledge Atlas Technology \(2513.HK\): Initiate with Neutral at US\\$110bn valuation; China's top enterprise/coding AI model](#), July 10, 2026

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Z.AI

We are Neutral rated on Z.AI with a 12-month target price of HK\$1,610. Our valuation is based on DCF valuation, with 12% WACC and 2% terminal growth rate (consistent with our coverage).

Key risks: **(+)** Stronger-than-expected model intelligence, **(+)** Faster-than-expected path to profit visibility, **(+)** Additional non-inference take rate revenue streams, **(+)** Stronger-than-expected commercialization capability, **(-)** Competition in global foundation model industry, **(-)** Limited near-term profit visibility due to high R&D expenses, **(-)** Cash burn/self-funding capability, **(-)** Risk around geopolitics under an intensified tech race between the US and China.

2513.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$1,610.00	Price: HK\$1,270.00	Upside: 26.8%
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Neutral	GS Forecast				
Market cap: HK\$591.3bn / \$75.4bn Enterprise value: HK\$556.2bn / \$70.9bn 3m ADTV: HK\$6.4bn / \$822.6mn China China Ecommerce & Logistics M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes		12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
	Revenue (Rmb mn)	724.3	8,575.3	24,625.5	57,899.8
	EBITDA (Rmb mn)	(3,505.7)	(5,046.5)	(5,711.5)	(2,235.0)
	EPS (Rmb)	(19.95)	(9.94)	(10.75)	(2.86)
	P/E (X)	NM	NM	NM	NM
	P/B (X)	NM	27.1	38.6	43.2
	Dividend yield (%)	NM	NM	NM	NM
	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	–	–	–	–
	CROCI (%)	NM	NM	NM	NM
	FCF yield (%)	–	(0.4)	(0.5)	(0.1)
		6/25	12/25	6/26E	12/26E
	EPS (Rmb)	(10.98)	(8.96)	(4.00)	(5.90)

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 14 Aug 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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Target price history table(s)

Z.AI Co. (2513.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
03-Aug-26	1,610.00	940.00
09-Jul-26	1,880.00	2,032.00

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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